suppose nobody can say Sven's decision wasn't the right one against Australia.

Our next competitive games were weeks away, so nobody was looking that far ahead. After losing to Australia that night in February, the England manager and the players took a beating in the press. There had been criticism of Sven ever since the World Cup. Our first European Championship qualifier for 2004 had been a really hard game, on a terrible field, away to Slovakia. We won but that didn't seem to matter: we were criticized in the press for playing without any style and without any passion. Me, I thought it was a great three points. Then, at home to Macedonia, despite playing some good soccer during the game, we only drew against a team we were supposed to beat easily. The flak got worse and, all of a sudden, it was as if the people who'd disapproved of Sven being appointed England coach had spotted their chance to try and hound him out of the job.

A lot of the criticism was focused on the fact that we'd fielded two completely different teams and on the club versus country debate. Ridiculous things were being said, like Sven not being strong enough to face up to the Premiership managers. For me, it wasn't a choice of playing for United or playing for England. United had been my life, as far as soccer was concerned, but that didn't mean I wasn't proud every time I played for my country too, especially as captain. Reading and listening to the fuss, I found myself wondering what the boss would be making of it all. Wondering if my career as an international soccer player—as well as the way I lived my life as a husband and father—might be part of the 'David Beckham Problem', as the Manchester United manager saw it. Of course I could think about all that, but there wasn't anything I could do about any of it right now. The important thing was getting back to Carrington to prepare for Arsenal at home in the FA Cup fifth round.

I remember the boss getting us all together beforehand. It wasn't just the England lads who'd been away from Old Trafford on international duty:

'You're back at the club now. It's a big game on Saturday. Make sure you get your heads right for it.'

There was a chill in the air between the two of us again. Something had annoyed the boss. I didn't know what. All I knew was I could feel the tension and I was convinced things were going to snap.

The game didn't go well. Arsenal scored from a lucky deflection off a free-kick. At half-time, the manager said he wasn't happy with how I was